they are both incredibly hard work, I don't think they can count as a job when you enjoy them as much as I do. My favourite time of the farming year is lambing, when over the last few years I have probably been around the most.

Though the lambing season starts as early as December in some areas, our busiest period is between mid-February and mid-April. I usually volunteer for late-night sessions in the lambing shed. It is a silent, hypnotic place, in which sheep, many of whom are first-time mothers, spend the night in individual pens with their offspring. At the risk of sounding soppy, helping a ewe to give birth is magical, a special feeling.

The lamb emerges with a splutter, shakes its head instinctively and can need to be cajoled into breathing using a piece of straw to clear mucus from its nasal passage. You need to act fast, and also disinfect its navel to prevent potential infection. The mother licks it dry before it rises, on matchstick thin legs, and totters around in search of the teats.

These are perilous moments; the lamb must suckle to get life-giving colostrum milk. It is golden, packed with essential nutrients, proteins and antibodies. A lamb needs 100 millilitres in its first few hours.

Occasionally you will need to help with the process if the ewe is unable to give birth by herself. You try to let the process happen naturally, but sometimes a helping hand is important. You push your hand gently inside her, never entirely knowing what you will find. In an ideal situation you ensure the legs emerge before the head, in a movement like a swan dive. Once the head and shoulders pass through the pelvis, the lamb slithers out.

Nature, like international sport, can be simultaneously cruel and wonderful. There was one story last winter that illustrates this. I had just started the evening shift when I noticed a sheep struggling. You try to give the sheep more time, but I quickly realized that it would need some assistance. Unfortunately, the forward twin was entangled with its brother in the womb and had died, but, given the constricted space, I couldn't untangle them. I was gutted, as no matter what I tried for the next hour or so I couldn't help the other lamb.

According to the vet, there was nothing I could do, so I reluctantly went to bed around midnight fearing the worst. I left for training early next morning, and couldn't believe it when Alice called to tell me the ewe had lambed naturally and she and the lamb were fine.